

Family trip

teams, building a reputation for solving problems by connecting the dots between products, problems, and people.

Malini repeatedly gravitated toward positions that connected disciplines rather than isolated them. Over the course of her career, she gained exposure to design, applications, field engineering, business strategy, customer engagement, and even the legal and operational aspects of the semiconductor industry. However, promotions did not always come easily, and there were few women role models around. "You're too emotional," or "You're not capable of running design teams because you've never done that before," she recalls hearing. But she kept repeating to herself: "I am emotional because I care, and I know I am capable because I am aware of my strengths. My team trusts me because I am empathetic, deliver technical results, and pack a pretty good punch playing tennis, so I am resilient. I had to say this to myself repeatedly to believe in myself when the world around me did not."

One of her ex-colleagues and close friends, Nisreen, was going through a similar journey and often became her sounding board. In lieu of a woman engineering role model, this was and remains very important, as they were dealing with very similar stereotypes and challenges.

But then Sameer from Renesas called her out of the blue on a Friday evening, believed in her and gave her an opportunity. Under her leadership, the Memory Interface Division team in India was built from the ground up, a milestone that demonstrated India's growing capability to contribute to global semiconductor innovation. It reflected many of the themes that had defined her career: technical depth, cross-functional collaboration, perseverance, and above all, the ability to bring people together around a shared goal.

At Renesas, those lessons came together in a much larger context. As the organisation expanded rapidly in India, Malini had to draw on the resilience, fearlessness, communication, multitasking, and organisational skills she had built over decades. The challenge was no longer only about succeeding in a role; it was about helping shape an organisation at scale.

A couple of years into her time at Renesas, one thing changed. "I no longer had to convince myself on repeat that I had to believe in myself. I got lucky to have some great mentors at Renesas. The only promotion I did not have to ask for in my career was when Shibata-san called me and told me about my promotion to Vice President at Renesas. This, coupled with other leaders and employees believing in me, gave me the conviction to simply believe in myself. This was a positive shift."



Morning workout in Japan to keep it going